

Fossil

Fossils are the preserved remains or traces of ancient animals and plants. Studying fossils helps us understand how organisms lived and evolved over time. Fossils are rare, because they form only in certain conditions over a long period of time.

Death and burial

Dying is probably the most important step in becoming fossilized! A fossil can only form if the dead animal or plant is buried quickly, because this helps slow its decay. Many fossils are formed in and around water, where remains soon sink into mud or a sandy bed.

This Stegosaurus was probably washed into the water by a high tide or flood.



Layers of rock

Tiny pieces of rock and minerals, called sediment, build up on top of the dead animal. Over time, these layers are squashed until they become solid rock, which presses down on the animal remains.

Sometimes the fossil is squashed, twisted, or flattened by the pressure of being buried.



Display While some fossils are put on display in museums, many are never seen by the public. These hidden treasures are studied by scientists called paleontologists.



Coprolite Coprolites are fossilized poop. The largest coprolite ever found is thought to have belonged to a T. rex and is more than 3 ft (1 m) long. Luckily, it doesn't smell anymore.

